Losing control

Khrushchev was adamant throughout that any decision to launch missiles at the United States would be taken in Moscow. He hand-picked General Pliyev for the mission, not for any expertise in missiles, but as someone Khrushchev could trust to obey orders. When the Presidium endorsed Khrushchev's idea to put nuclear missiles in Cuba, it was clear they did not intend to relinquish authority over fighting a nuclear war. There was, of course, no guarantee that Pliyev would be alive or able to communicate with his base commanders in the event of attack, and as seen in chapter six, his subordinates were unable to contact him when they judged it necessary to fire the S-75s that brought down Major Anderson's U-2. It is more than likely that a US attack on the MRBMs would have been completely successful. US troops would, nevertheless, have faced a nuclear threat from the one hundred or so Soviet tactical nuclear weapons on the island.

Over recent decades, historians have acquired knowledge that challenged hitherto accepted ideas about the risk of nuclear war. Historians know what political (and military) leaders did not. The most perplexing decisions taken in Moscow concerned deployment of Soviet tactical nuclear weapons in Cuba.[72] These were firmly integrated into Soviet operational doctrine. Yet, there are no indications that serious consideration was given within the Presidium – or by Khrushchev – to the implications of starting a limited nuclear war in (or in the seas around) Cuba when decisions about their deployment were made. It was not until shortly before Kennedy delivered his televised address on 22 October that the Presidium seems to have first addressed the matter (when it decided tactical nuclear weapons should not be used in response to an invasion).

The original plan for Operation Anadyr included eighty Meteor cruise missiles with variable-yield warheads of between five and twelve kilotons. Two regiments, each of forty missiles, were deployed: one to defend against US landings near Mariel in the west; the other to attack the US base at Guantánamo in the east. US military planners were unaware that Soviet nuclear missiles would be targeted at Guantánamo. The US military, was conscious of the threat from (what it saw as) conventionally armed cruise